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Wars are not won by tanks, ships, guns, fighter jets, submarines or nuclear bombs—wars are won by human beings. The world's greatest armies fighting in the greatest wars understood that war was a business, and if one was to win at it, one would have to conduct it according to established principles. How does one find a workforce fit enough to fight in a war? Eventually, men and women, whose trade it was to find a solution to problems such as these were consulted—psychologists who devised tests, by means of which they were able to measure intelligence, aptitude and adaptability. These tests helped handpick men and women fit to become future leaders, and also helped weed out the incompetent. Ingenious schemes were put into operation to bring together a group of individuals of similar intellectual standard to facilitate military training. It all went well for the psychologists. As a result, it was concluded that the only thing that mattered in war, besides physical strength, was mental attitude. Only the greatest leaders in history have been able to understand and exploit it.

For any leader, defeat is just an attitude; it resides in the mind and is not a physical condition. And this attitude varies from person to person. To find a person in possession of the right kind of mental attitude and psychological strength required to lead in battle, the Indian defence forces came up with a sequence of psychological tests that formed the major chunk of the SSB exam: the Word Association Test (WAT), the Thematic Appreciation Test